



Postpartum

planning guide



Contact:
07814504865
@birthhooduk
leanne@birth-hood.co.uk
www.birth-hood.co.uk

Leanne xx

postnatal expectations/planning

So much time and energy is spent preparing for birth, yet the days and weeks after birth—the fourth trimester—are where families often need the most support. This is a time of profound transition, when your baby is adjusting to life outside the womb and you are adjusting to life as a parent.

Your newborn's needs are simple but intense: closeness, warmth, feeding, and responsive care. Frequent waking, cluster feeding, and a strong desire to be held are not signs of “bad habits”—they are normal, biologically driven behaviours that help your baby feel safe and secure. Planning ahead for these realities can make the early weeks feel less overwhelming and more supported.

At the same time, your body and mind are undergoing enormous change. Hormones shift rapidly after birth, which can affect your emotions, energy levels, and sense of identity. Feeling tearful, sensitive, euphoric, anxious, or unsure at times is common—and you are not alone. Preparing for this emotional landscape, alongside practical needs like meals, rest, feeding support, and household help, can create a softer landing into parenthood.

Postpartum planning is not about perfection—it's about permission: permission to rest, to ask for help, to move slowly, and to prioritise connection over productivity. By thinking ahead about support, boundaries, and nourishment—both physical and emotional—you give yourself and your baby the best possible start in this tender, transformative season.

Research consistently shows that practical support, emotional validation, and realistic expectations significantly improve parental wellbeing and reduce the risk of postnatal anxiety and depression. Preparing for the fourth trimester is one of the most powerful ways to care for yourself and your baby.

Key themes:

- Talk openly about how life might change after birth.
- Normalise feelings of uncertainty, grief for old routines, or identity shifts.
- Create space for connection, not perfection.

Becoming a parent is a major psychological transition. Mixed emotions are normal—even when a baby is deeply wanted and loved.

postnatal expectations/planning

After pains

The cramps known as afterbirth pains, or simply afterpains, are caused by contractions of your uterus as it returns to its pre-pregnancy size after you have your baby, and expels any clots. (This process is called "involution.")

This can intensify when feeding, but is not usually something to be concerned about, and is often more common after subsequent births. Taking paracetamol or ibuprofen is safe and can help.

Bleeding (AKA Lochia)

It usually begins straight after birth and can continue for up to six weeks postpartum; however, the heaviest flow tends to be during the first two weeks. you may find clots, anything bigger than a 50p should be monitored and anything bigger than your palm should be checked. Between around days four and 10, lochia should get lighter and have a more pinkish or brownish hue. This will still happen following a caesarean.

Never use a tampon!

Swelling

You may experience some vaginal swelling as well as swelling to your vulva. This is quite common, and usually reduces after 2-3 days.

Use 'padsickles' (maternity pad, soaked in aloe and witch hazel and popped into the freezer) to help, plus arnica to reduce any bruising.

Other areas may still have excess water, but this too should reduce in a couple of weeks!

Stitches

If you've had stitches after tearing or an episiotomy, keep them clean by bathing daily, to help prevent infection. Use plain warm water then carefully pat yourself dry. If your stitches are sore or uncomfortable, tell your midwife.

Stitches usually dissolve themselves, but sometimes they have to be taken out- check with your midwife.

Using a Peribottle (or just a jug of warm water) may help reduce any stinging also.

Baby blues

Are due to a sudden drop of hormones, which your body tries to process over the first few days post birth.

Symptoms of baby blues include: feeling emotional, irrational or overwhelmed, tearful (without knowing why), irritable and moody and down or anxious. They usually pass, but if you find they're sticking around, seek support from your midwife or other agencies including PANDAS.

Colostrum

Colostrum is a highly concentrated form of breast milk and is what your breast/chest produces in the first few days after your baby being born. Because it's so concentrated, colostrum often has a thick consistency, and a golden yellow colour.

Colostrum contains high levels of fat, protein and carbohydrates, so your baby will be able to get plenty of nutrition even from the small quantities you produce.*liquidgold*

Going to the loo

You might be shitting yourself (excuse the pun) at the thought of going to the loo post birth.

Try not to hold it, your bladder may have lower levels of control, so go as soon as you feel it. Drink lots to dilute the urine too.

You probably won't have a poo for a few days after the birth, but it's important not to let yourself get constipated. Eat lots of fibre and drink lots of water to help keep your stools soft, occasionally a laxative may be helpful. (p.s. its very unliely your stutches will burst).

Piles

Piles can be quite common (yes I had them).

Try not to push or strain when going to the toilet to help prevent and use 'Anusol' or similar to help the discomfort of they happen. They usually go away within a few days. Be aware of your diet to help your stolls stay soft too.

Night Sweats

Postpartum sweating and night sweats are very common and normal, and they usually go away after a few weeks. Strategies that can help include drinking plenty of water to prevent dehydration, and taking a lukewarm or cool shower before bed

Any questions or if you want any support, always contact me and I can signpost/support you if necessary.



postnatal plan

SOCIAL SUPPORT: WHO CAN PROVIDE YOU SOCIAL SUPPORT? FAMILY, FRIENDS, NEIGHBOURS, DOULAS, OR ONLINE?

- *** parents
- Antenatal group
- Leanne
- Peanut App
- (visits, texts, calls, baby groups etc.)
- Night feeding!

REST: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOU GET ENOUGH REST? HELP WITH HOUSEHOLD, VISITORS, NAPS, RELAXATION TECHNIQUES ETC?

- Lots of rest- *** to support between baby feeds.
- Leanne to support for rest.
- Cleaner/Dog walker to help
- *** parents - Cooks
- Ring doorbell? Door sign? Food drop off? Deliveries?
- Baths and rest, music to switch off, Insta scroll.
- Schedule naps.
- No visitors between 1-3 or after 6

EXAMPLE

FOOD: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOUR BODY IS NOURISHED? BATCH COOK, FOOD DELIVERIES, SUBSCRIPTIONS, SNACKS?

- Batch cooking
- Food vouchers
- Leanne support
- Snack basket (cereal bars, sweets, choc, bananas, dates, nuts)
- Smoothies
- Switch meals (main at lunch)

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT/SELF CARE: HOW WILL ENSURE YOUR RECOVERY PRIORITISES YOU, YOUR HEALING BODY, YOUR EMOTIONAL NEEDS, FRIENDS, FAMILY, PHYSIOTHERAPIST, MASSAGE TECHNIQUES, POSTNATAL SUPPORT?

- Self care: moving, walk around block, being outside, showers
- Do make up
- Postnatal support massage
- Leanne - postpartum yoga support.
- If want massage/hair etc, can use Leanne to support with baby etc.

Think about-

- You and your baby's immediate needs
- You and your baby's secondary needs

planning prompts

- Make a list of all the possible people that could come to support and help you get some rest after the birth.
- Explain ahead of time what you will be trying to achieve and ask for specific help from people. People love to help; they just don't know how to do it most times.
- Keep early afternoons free for napping, which is when most of us are at our sleepiest.
- Make a note for the door to avoid being woken up during your nap or by unwanted visitors. Something like "New mother and baby sleeping, please don't knock or ring the doorbell, leave deliveries by the door/in this safe place/with neighbours/come back later".
- Try to rest. You may have heard the expression sleep when the baby sleeps there is some wisdom in it. If you cannot sleep, you could simply lie down and relax and/or listen to a relaxation track.
- Choose your supporters wisely, in that ideally, they should be both helpful and make you feel good. Having a bossy mother in law that irritates you isn't going to make for restful time. Nor is having a relative who expects to be waited upon. If you can afford it, consider hiring a postnatal doula. Or get family and friends to buy you doula vouchers. There are so many reasons for why this can be a game changer.
- Get your partner on board with your postnatal need for rest (if you have a partner). The first cause of conflict in couples after the birth of a baby is "who does what". Sit down with your partner, and separately write a list of all the chores and who does them. Then sit down and compare notes. Work together through what tasks can be dumped, outsourced, and taken on by the partner. The book "Baby's here! who does what?" by Duncan Fisher is a useful and easy to read resource.
- Plan for "one week in bed, one week around the bed/on the sofa".
- Batch cook and freeze food, ask for visitors to bring you homemade dishes, get some food delivered, stock up on nutritious snacks.
- Ask for gifts for yourself rather than the baby. This can include food deliveries, vouchers for a postnatal doula or a postnatal massage or bodywork, offers to come and look after your baby so you can sleep etc (check my post on Instagram/Facebook!)
- Think about who can hold/feed baby. What would you like?
- Plan for the unplanned. You might want to make sure that your plan includes possible curveballs, such as having a long induction or a caesarean, or if you and/or your baby need to stay in hospital for a while.
- Prepare for your emotional and physical needs (infection etc).

Ultimately, look after yourselves- RECOVER

- REST
- EAT
- CHORES
- OPTIONAL (If you prefer to go out and socialise, you can!)
- VISITORS
- EMOTIONAL
- RECEIVE



postnatal plan

SOCIAL SUPPORT: WHO CAN PROVIDE YOU SOCIAL SUPPORT? FAMILY, FRIENDS, NEIGHBOURS, DOULAS, OR ONLINE?

REST: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOU GET ENOUGH REST? HELP WITH HOUSEHOLD, VISITORS, NAPS, RELAXATION TECHNIQUES ETC?

FOOD: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOUR BODY IS NOURISHED? BATCH COOK, FOOD DELIVERIES, SUBSCRIPTIONS, SNACKS?

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT/SELF CARE: HOW WILL ENSURE YOUR RECOVERY PRIORITISES YOU, YOUR HEALING BODY, YOUR EMOTIONAL NEEDS, FRIENDS, FAMILY, PHYSIOTHERAPIST, MASSAGE TECHNIQUES, POSTNATAL SUPPORT?

Think about-

- You and your baby's immediate needs
- You and your baby's secondary needs